MPI New Zealand: the world's strictest biosecurity system and quarantine requirements for pets

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Abstract

Objective. To describe the MPI New Zealand biosecurity system for dog and cat importation, its mandatory quarantine protocols, and the specific requirements applicable to animals from Peru. **Method.** Review of current MPI Import Health Standards (IHS), pre-export requirements, quarantine procedures at approved facilities, and country classification criteria based on rabies and other disease risk. **Results.** New Zealand applies the world's strictest mandatory quarantine system for pets: 10 days at MPI-approved facilities for all dogs and cats regardless of country of origin. Prerequisites include ISO microchip, rabies vaccination, serology >=0.5 IU/mL and certified antiparasitic treatment. **Conclusion.** The process has a minimum duration of 6 months from primary vaccination to arrival at destination, requiring exhaustive planning and coordination with an approved importer.

Keywords: MPI New Zealand, Import Health Standards, mandatory quarantine, biosecurity, RFFIT, pet importation, Peru

New Zealand maintains the most demanding pet importation regime in the world. The Ministry for Primary Industries (MPI) applies a country risk classification system, mandatory post-arrival quarantine of up to 10 days, and comprehensive serological and parasitological requirements. This article analyses the current Import Health Standard and the full protocol for exports from Peru.

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Scope of this article Descriptive technical document based on the MPI Import Health Standard current as of January 2026. Always verify at mpi.govt.nz before starting any export process, as IHS documents are periodically updated.

Section 1 -- Why New Zealand is the world's most demanding destination

New Zealand is a geographically isolated archipelago in the South Pacific that has maintained freedom from rabies, leptospirosis, and multiple other infectious and parasitic diseases through an import biosecurity policy among the strictest in the world. The Ministry for Primary Industries (MPI) manages this system through Import Health Standards (IHS), technical documents with the force of law that establish specific requirements by species and country of origin.

The underlying philosophy of the New Zealand system differs from other regulatory frameworks such as those of the EU or USA: while the latter permit entry without quarantine when documentary requirements are met, New Zealand assumes that no document constitutes an absolute guarantee and requires mandatory post-arrival quarantine for all animals from countries classified in the highest-risk groups, regardless of the quality of the documentation presented.

1.1 The Import Health Standard as a regulatory instrument

IHS documents are the New Zealand equivalent of import requirements in other countries, but with one critical particularity: they have the force of law under the Biosecurity Act

1993 and are updated by MPI periodically -- usually every 3-5 years or whenever there are significant changes in the global animal health landscape. The current IHS for dogs and cats exhaustively establishes requirements by risk group, including not only vaccination and serology, but also parasitological treatments with strict time windows, health certificates in a specific MPI format, and mandatory post-arrival quarantine procedures including duration, approved facilities, and monitoring protocols.

1.2 The microchip: critical sequence in New Zealand

As with other destinations, the ISO 11784/11785 microchip must be implanted before any treatment or procedure forming part of the export protocol. In the case of New Zealand, this is especially relevant because the first mandatory antiparasitic treatment must also be performed with the animal already identified. A microchip implanted after the first parasitological treatment invalidates that treatment and requires it to be repeated, adding weeks to an already lengthy process. The microchip must be an ISO-standard transponder readable by standard ISO 11784/11785 scanners; non-standard chips not readable by MPI biosecurity scanners are not accepted.

Section 2 -- Country classification by risk group

MPI classifies countries of origin into distinct risk groups based on their animal health profile, with progressively more demanding requirements:

Group 1: lowest-risk countries

Includes Australia and a very limited number of Pacific island countries with health status equivalent to New Zealand's. Group 1 animals may enter without post-arrival quarantine if all documentary requirements are met, which are significantly less demanding -- RFFIT is generally not required, and the process is considerably faster and less costly overall.

Group 2: moderate-risk countries

Includes most European countries with strong rabies control records and without other diseases prioritized by New Zealand's biosecurity framework. RFFIT with result ≥0.5 IU/mL is required, and post-arrival quarantine duration is shorter than for Group 3.

Group 3: rest of world (includes Peru)

Peru is classified in Group 3, along with most of Latin America, Africa, Asia and other countries whose health profile is not equivalent to New Zealand's. This is the group with the greatest technical demands and the mandatory 10-day post-arrival quarantine at an MPI-approved facility -- an obligation that cannot be waived under any circumstances.

Group 3: unavoidable quarantine For animals from Peru (Group 3), the 10-day post-arrival quarantine at an MPI-approved facility is mandatory and unavoidable, even if all documents are perfectly in order. There is no exemption or alternative procedure. The owner must plan quarantine costs (approximately NZD 1,200-1,800 per animal, roughly USD 730-1,100) and the period of separation from the animal from the very start of the process.

Section 3 -- Full protocol for Group 3 from Peru

3.1 Mandatory technical sequence

The sequence of steps is strictly ordered: any deviation from the sequence -- such as drawing blood for RNATT before the 30-day post-vaccine window, or administering the antiparasitic too early -- invalidates the affected step and may require restarting from that point. The complete sequence is:

- ISO 11784/11785 microchip implanted before any other procedure in the protocol.
- Rabies vaccination with an authorized inactivated vaccine, animal already microchipped, at least 12 weeks of age. The vaccine must be within its validity period (1 or 3 years depending on the manufacturer and revaccination schedule).

- 30-day wait after primary vaccination before blood collection for RFFIT/FAVN (termed RNATT in MPI nomenclature).
- RNATT (RFFIT or FAVN) at an MPI-approved laboratory: result ≥0.5 IU/mL. MPI maintains its own list of approved laboratories including facilities in the USA, Australia and Europe. No Peruvian laboratory is currently MPI-approved; samples are typically sent to KSVDL (Kansas, USA) or equivalent.
- 6-month wait from the date of the positive RNATT result before traveling to New Zealand. This 6-month waiting period is the key differentiator from Australia (3 months) or the UK (3 months). It applies to Group 3 countries regardless of the RNATT titre level achieved.
- Antiparasitic treatments within strict time windows before the flight (against ectoparasites, helminths, and Echinococcus depending on species).
- Health certificate in MPI-specific format, issued by a SENASA-accredited official veterinarian, within the established deadlines before the flight.
- 10-day post-arrival quarantine at an MPI-approved facility upon landing in New Zealand.

Minimum total timeline from Peru (Group 3) The combination of 30 days post-vaccine + RNATT laboratory time (2-4 weeks) + 6-month wait + antiparasitic treatments + health certificate equals a minimum of 7.5-9 months from the first vaccination to the flight. Adding the 10-day quarantine at destination, the complete process from start until the owner recovers their animal exceeds 8 months under ideal conditions -- and closer to 10 months when real-world delays are factored in.

3.2 Antiparasitic treatments and their time windows

MPI requires specific treatments against different parasite groups, each with distinct time windows relative to the date of arrival in New Zealand. The principal requirements are:

- Against ectoparasites (ticks, fleas): treatment with an MPI-approved product within a window of 14-21 days before arrival, recorded in the health certificate with the product name, batch number and date of administration.

- Against intestinal helminths: treatment with an approved product (praziquantel or combination with fenbendazole) within a specified period before travel. The product must appear on the MPI-approved products list.

- Against Echinococcus (dogs only): praziquantel at a minimum dose of 5 mg/kg, within 14 days before arrival. This window is broader than the UK's 24-120 hour window but the product approval list is different -- not all UK-approved products appear on the MPI list.

- Leishmaniasis screening (if applicable): for animals from endemic zones, MPI may require additional diagnostic tests. Peru's coastal and highland regions have varying Leishmania exposure levels; your veterinarian should assess this risk in the pre-export evaluation.

Mandatory verification of MPI-approved products Not all antiparasitic products available in Peru -- including internationally recognized brands -- appear on the MPI approved products list. Using a non-listed product, even one that is pharmacologically equivalent, may invalidate the documented treatment. Always verify the current approved products list at mpi.govt.nz before selecting the antiparasitic, as the list is updated periodically.

Section 4 -- Quarantine in New Zealand: logistics and animal welfare

4.1 MPI-approved facilities

Companion animal quarantine facilities in New Zealand are operated by MPI-accredited private companies. The main facilities are the Levin Animal Quarantine Service (in Levin, Manawatu region, approximately 100 km south of Wellington) and facilities near Auckland. Most international flights arrive in Auckland, from where animals are transported to the designated quarantine facility. The cost of the 10-day quarantine ranges from NZD 1,200 to NZD 1,800 per animal (approximately USD 730-1,100), excluding airport-to-facility transport. These costs must be paid prior to the animal's release.

4.2 What happens during quarantine

During the 10 days of quarantine, facility staff perform daily clinical observation of the animal, document verification, and may request additional diagnostic tests if the animal shows clinical signs or if documentary discrepancies are detected. Owners may visit their animals at the facility according to each center's internal protocols. After 10 days, if the animal shows no clinical or documentary findings justifying retention, it is released to the owner without further procedures. MPI has documented cases of animals being deported to their country of origin when documentation was found to be incomplete or falsified -- the cost of the return journey and any additional quarantine falls entirely on the owner.

4.3 Animal welfare impact

The 10-day quarantine at a supervised facility, combined with the stress of long-haul air travel (Lima-Auckland generally involves more than 18 hours of flight with one or two stopovers), has a measurable impact on animal welfare. Animals with pre-existing chronic conditions -- cardiac, hepatic, or respiratory disease -- or brachycephalic breeds with high travel-stress sensitivity are particularly vulnerable. Pre-export veterinary assessment should include a fitness-for-flight and fitness-for-quarantine evaluation, not just serological status. Animals with borderline cardiac or respiratory function may not be suitable candidates for this journey regardless of their serological compliance.

Section 5 -- Differences between dogs and cats in the MPI system

Dogs and cats share most IHS requirements for Group 3, but important differences exist in the antiparasitic treatments required and in some additional vaccination requirements:

- Praziquantel (Echinococcus): mandatory for dogs; not required for cats.
- Treatment against Toxocara: required for both species but with different approved products and doses; confirm the species-specific list before treatment.

- Leptospirosis vaccination: required for dogs in certain groups; not applicable to cats.
- Health certificate format: the MPI format is different for dogs and cats; using the incorrect form invalidates the document entirely.
- Flight requirements: MPI-approved carriers may have different crate size and temperature requirements for dogs versus cats; verify with the specific airline before booking.

Section 6 -- Most frequent errors in Peru-New Zealand exports

6.1 Assuming 3-month rather than 6-month waiting period

The most frequent and most costly error: the owner starts the process assuming the post-RNATT waiting period is 3 months (as in the UK or Australia), and purchases a ticket to travel 3 months after the result. Upon verifying the actual requirements, they discover they must wait 6 months, implying ticket changes and additional costs. The 6-month period for Group 3 is unambiguously established in the current IHS and admits no exceptions.

6.2 Non-MPI-approved RNATT laboratory

MPI maintains its own list of approved laboratories for RFFIT/FAVN that is not identical to the USDA or EU approved laboratory lists. An RFFIT result from a USDA-approved laboratory may not be recognized by MPI if that laboratory does not appear on MPI's specific list. Always verify at mpi.govt.nz before sending the sample, and keep confirmation that the selected laboratory was on the MPI list on the date the sample was tested.

6.3 Non-MPI-approved antiparasitic products

Many antiparasitic products marketed in Peru -- including internationally recognized brand-name products -- are not on the MPI approved products list. Using a non-listed product invalidates that documented treatment and may require repeating it with an

MPI-approved product, with the associated timeline implications. This error is particularly costly when it is discovered at the point of entry, where the animal may face extended quarantine or deportation.

6.4 Health certificate in incorrect format

MPI requires its own health certificate format, different from the US APHIS Form 7001, the UK Animal Health Certificate, or the EU third-country official certificate. The certificate must be downloaded from the MPI portal, completed in English, and endorsed by SENASA before travel. A certificate in any format other than the MPI-specific one is rejected at the port of entry, regardless of how accurate its content may be.

Clinical experience -- Zoovet Travel 2013-2026 New Zealand is the destination with the highest number of pre-process consultations abandoned after the first information session. 67% of owners contacting Zoovet Travel to export to New Zealand withdraw upon learning the total timeline (7-9 months), quarantine costs (NZD 1,200-1,800) and the inevitability of the 10-day post-arrival quarantine. The 33% who decide to continue generally do so with the advantage of having planned sufficiently in advance, significantly reducing the risk of error. The most important piece of advice for any Peru-New Zealand process: start planning at least 10 months before the intended travel date.

Figure 1. MPI New Zealand — entry pathway by country group.

Adapted from MPI Import Health Standard IHS 154.02.06 (2024) and CATDOG.GEN. Verify the live IHS at mpi.govt.nz before each export.

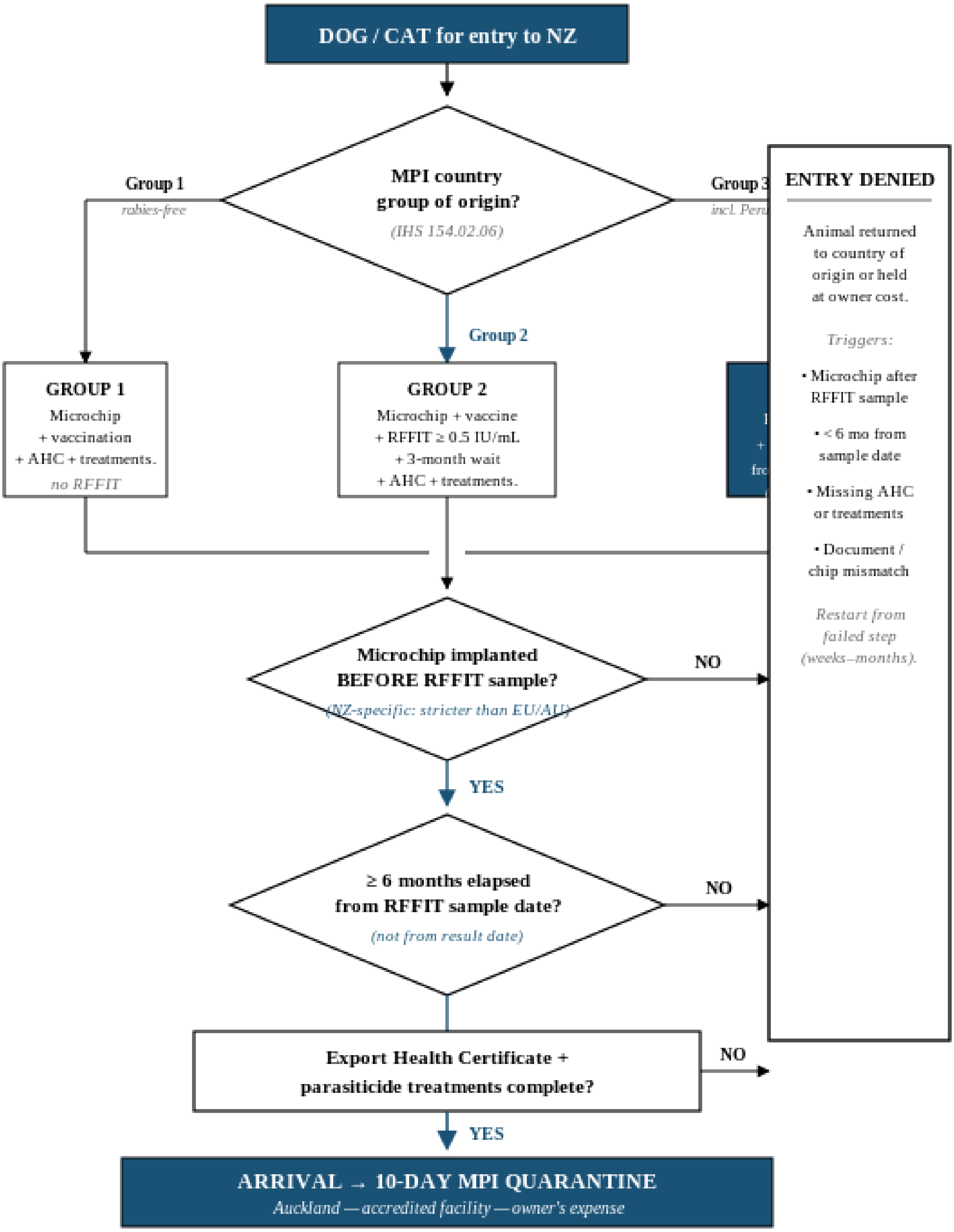
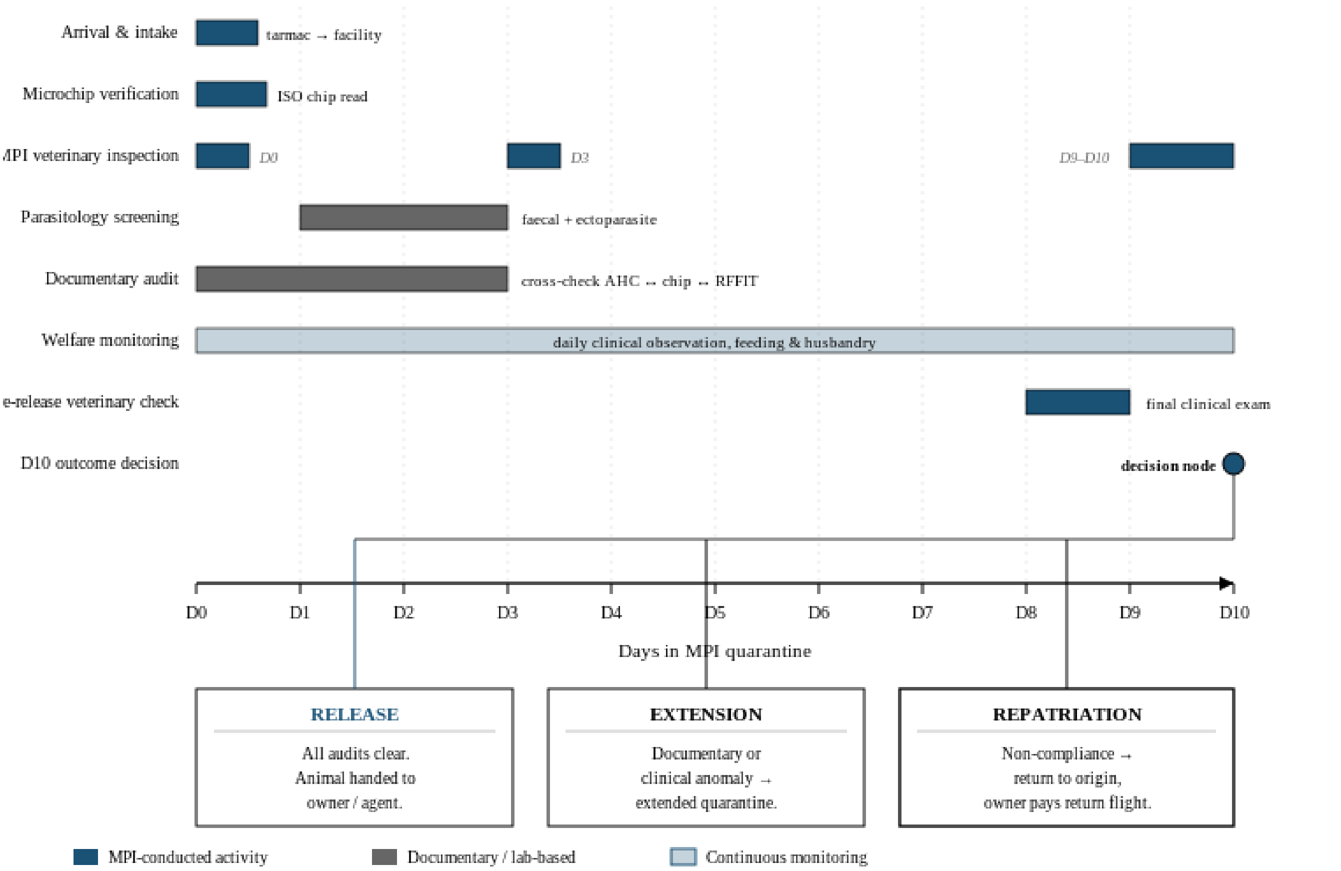


Figure 2. Mandatory quarantine sequence — MPI-accredited facility, Auckland.

Schematic Gantt of post-arrival activities for dogs/cats from Group 3 countries (incl. Peru). All costs borne by the owner. Source: MPI IHS 154.02.06.



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